CONSULTATION ON THESIS TOPIC CHOICE
(BACHELOR LEVEL)

Student Data: (To be filled in by the student)	
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Programme: International Business and Economics (in the language English)	
Supervisor: (To be filled in by the student)	
Name: Dr. Patrick Baude	

1. **Topic** (definition of the problem/research question in one sentence)**:**

   How do non-traditional economic indicators, such as the Hemline and Lipstick Index, reflect differences in consumer culture and fashion representation in Hungary and France across major economic and social turning points?

2. **Expected results, benefits, and added value (**unless the topic automatically implies it)**:**

   The thesis will examine how unconventional indicators (the Hemline Index and the Lipstick Index), reflect consumer culture in Hungary and France across major social and economic turning points. It will identify whether these indicators show visible shifts that correspond with main historical events and to compare how similar or different the shifts between the two countries. Also, to see how culture and economy intersect during global events (like the 2008 Financial Crisis, the COVID-19 Pandemic etc.) or local/national events (Hungary EU accession in 2004, France Eurozone crisis etc.)

   The added value lies in constructing an original dataset from magazines, which allows for cross-country comparison and a cultural-economic interpretation of fashion trends. This research may contribute to a better understanding of how fashion and consumption patterns reflect economic changes and political events. It can also enrich the literature on non-traditional economic indicators and add value to those who interested in consumer behaviour, fashion and the change behind fashion trends and its volume.

3. **Suggestions concerning the elaboration of the topic** (recommended literature, theoretical framework, data to be used, methods of data collection and data analysis, etc.)[1]

   I will conduct my own search for the dataset, where I will use Hungarian and French women's fashion and lifestyle magazines. For the Hemline Index, I will code and quantify skirt and dress lengths as seen in the fashion pictures, advertisements, and covers. For the Lipstick Index, I will count and categorise advertisements for cosmetics (lipsticks as affordable luxury items) and for high-end fashion goods (e.g., bags as expensive luxury items). This will allow me to construct a structured dataset capturing changes in fashion and consumer imagery.

   The comparison will also focus on selecting historical and economic turning points. Then, compare the gathered magazine dataset and analyse them before and after period around these events, for both Hungary and France. The main analytical method will be cross-sectional and comparative: descriptive statistics, visualisation of trends, and statistical tests (e.g., chi-square or

[1] It is the responsibility of the author/student to ensure that all data and information contained in the Project Work/Thesis is used in a lawful manner. According to faculty regulations, the work cannot be made confidential.

regression on categorical outcomes) to examine whether there are systematic differences in hemline lengths or advertisement patterns across countries and periods.

The added methodological value lies in generating an original dataset from archival sources (magazines available in libraries, digital archives, or microfilm). Reliability will be ensured using a coding framework. Then, the gathered data will be interpreted as cultural-economic reflections of broader societal and economic transformations in Hungary and France.

Magazines: In which I plan to look one issues per month at least to ensure consistency.

- For Hungarian women fashion magazines:
    - Nők Lapja (Women's Magazine), which is a women's lifestyle magazine with a very broad and mainstream audience
    - Glamour Hungary, with not a high luxury but an accessible luxury magazine directed towards women. It is great to gather data for the bag and lipstick advertisement
- For France women fashion magazines:
    - Elle (France), also an affordable luxury magazine. Perfect representation for the Lipstick Index. But this magazine also has many fashion topics.
    - Marie-Claire, which is also a lifestyle magazine like Nők Lapja. With many journalism and social issues in it.
    - Glamour (French edition) is an accessible luxury magazine.

Publications:

- Van Baardwijk, M., & Franses, P. H. (2010). The hemline and the economy: Is there any match? Econometric Institute Report No. EI 2010-40, Erasmus School of Economics, Erasmus University Rotterdam
- Kim, S., & Ahn, I. (2015, November 12). Impact of macro-economic factors on the hemline cycles. In International Textile & Apparel Association Annual Conference Proceedings, 72(1).
- Legka, N. (2013). The Hemline and Economy (Master's thesis, Kyiv School of Economics). Kyiv, Ukraine. Supervisor: Tom Coupe.
- Humes, G. M. (2021). Hemline theory: Testing the relationship between fashion trends and the stock market (B.B.A. thesis, Kent State University). Kent State University – OhioLINK Electronic Theses and Dissertations Center.
- MacDonald, D., & Dildar, Y. (2020). Social and psychological determinants of consumption: Evidence for the lipstick effect during the Great Recession. Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Economics, 86, Article 101527.
- Hill, S. E., Rodeheffer, C. D., Griskevicius, V., Durante, K., & White, A. E. (2012). Boosting beauty in an economic decline: Mating, spending, and the lipstick effect. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 103(2), 275-291. DOI:10.1037/a0028657

- Bahl, A., De La Garza, H., Lam, C., & Vashi, N. A. (2022). The lipstick effect during COVID-19 lockdown. Clinics in Dermatology, 40(3), 299-302. DOI:10.1016/j.clindermatol.2021.11.002

4. Parts of the Thesis to prepare within the framework of Project Work 1.

	Only mark here if the given part is required	
	exhaustively	partially
Introduction	X	
Background information, literature review	X	
Justification for the choice of methodology/theoretical framework	X	
Description of the scope of the data to be collected and of the data collection method(s)		X
Detailed research plan		X
Outline of the planned interviews, presentation of the planned questionnaires, etc.		X
Other, namely:		

Other comments, instructor's expectations, etc.:

The literature review, methodology, data collection, outline of the analysis section should be ready for final submission of PW1.

By November 21, 2025 the draft work must be uploaded to moodle with a minimum of 80-90% completion so that the final version can be ready by the December deadline.

Budapest, 27 September, 2025